

# To prosper, organizational psychology should. . . expand the values of organizational psychology to match the quality of its ethics<sup>†</sup>

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## Summary

The values of organizational psychology are criticized as (a) having supplanted psychology's humanist tradition and societal responsibilities with corporate economic objectives; (b) being "scientistic" in perpetuating the notion of value-free science while ignoring that it is business values that largely drive our research and practice; (c) failing to include normative perspectives of what organizations ought to be like in moral terms; (d) having a pro-management bias; and (e) having allowed ourselves to be defined largely by technocratic competence, almost to the exclusion of considering desirable societal goods. Illustrations of some adverse consequences of these values are presented. It is suggested we expand our self-image to encompass a scientist–practitioner–humanist (S-P-H) model that includes consideration of different values, advocacy of employee rights and a normative characterization of how organizations ought to be—reflecting the broader societal responsibilities of a true profession. Copyright © 2008 John Wiley & Sons, Ltd.

## Introduction

The relatively recently emergent field of *moral psychology*, consisting of "attempts to analyze moral phenomena in terms of psychological concepts and processes" (Emler & Hogan, 1991, p. 72) defines *moral behavior* as reflecting principled adherence to higher level standards than mere social consensus or sanctions. Moral psychologists have generally partitioned moral behavior into two dimensions: *justice issues*—encompassing notions of fairness, impartiality, and universalizability; and *welfare* or *caring*, reflecting criteria of beneficence, avoiding harm, and altruism. One recent treatment of the topic has added a third dimension, referred to by such labels as *honesty*, *integrity*, or *moral virtue* (Lefkowitz, 2003). Its inclusion makes more explicit the relevance of personal values issues that underlie ethical

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<sup>†</sup>I use the term organizational psychology very broadly. To the extent that many of the concerns expressed here pertain to areas of application and to human resources administration, they may be more apt for those of us who have the perspective of industrial–organizational psychology.

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behavior. Thus, the generic ethical question shifts from a focus almost entirely on “What is the right thing to do?” to include “What kind of person shall I be?”

So, with both ethics and values providing a frame of reference that has been called “the domain of moral action” (Lefkowitz, 2003, 2006) what could I say legitimately, first, about the ethics of organizational psychologists? Do we seem to stand out as particularly self-serving, norm-breaking, unjust, uncaring, and/or dishonest, that is, more so than any other professional group, or than the rest of society? I do not think so. [With regard to the documented unethical behavior of psychologists, it is clear that the most frequent problems arise elsewhere—primarily concerning inappropriate sexual behavior by therapists with their clients (e.g., American Psychological Association, 2005).] Nor have I encountered any evidence to suggest that “organizational misbehavior,” “workplace deviance” (Vardi & Weitz, 2004) or even mere incivility are attributes particularly characteristic of us. In other words, all-in-all as a profession I do not think we are marked by notable or major ethical deficiencies. On a personal level, I do not know that I have ever encountered an organizational psychologist who I thought was not trying to do the ethically correct thing—as he or she saw it.

So, what is there to talk about?

The key is in the qualifier proffered above when I indicted that I had never encountered an organizational psychologist who was not trying to do the ethically correct thing—as *he or she* saw it. And that is a matter of goals and objectives. With profound apologies to The Bard: “*the fault, dear colleagues, lies not in our ethics, but in our values.*”<sup>1</sup> At the individual level, it is one’s personal values that shape one’s moral sensitivities and ethical behavior. It is a *profession’s* values that determine its goals and self-construed duties, responsibilities, and ethical standards, its response to sociopolitical events that affect it (e.g., civil rights legislation; rampant downsizing), and the choices made by its members concerning where they work, what they study, and the criteria by which they evaluate that work.

## Professional Values

There are a number of attributes that are generally conceded to characterize a profession and which distinguish it from occupations that have not achieved that distinction (Freidson, 1986; Haber, 1991). Among these attributes are a core body of theoretical knowledge, the enjoyment of considerable societal power (e.g., interpretive authority in its domain—as exemplified by the legal deference paid to the Society for Industrial–Organizational Psychology’s *Principles for the Validation and Use of Personnel Selection Procedures* [2003]), a distinctive culture, existence of a code of ethics, etc. (cf. Lefkowitz, 2003 for a review). Among the important attributes is an assumption of responsibility beyond its direct clients to the society at-large which has granted the profession its considerable power and authority. The acknowledgment of this broad service orientation has been referred to as “the professional model” (Hall, 1975, p. 72) or “the true professional ideal” (Kimball, 1992, p. 303). It is reflected in the profession of psychology by a long-standing humanist tradition which, in addition to the scientific tradition, represents one of “psychology’s two cultures” (Kimble, 1984), and finds contemporary expression in the American Psychological Association’s ethical code, which commits us to using the scientific and professional knowledge we produce “to improve the condition of individuals, organizations, and society” (APA, 2002, Preamble).

<sup>1</sup> Values are defined, here, as “relatively stable cognitive representations of what the person believes are desirable standards of conduct or generalized end states. They have affective and evaluative components in that they are experienced in terms of their relative importance in the person’s ideal self-concept; they have a motivational component in that they serve to initiate and guide people’s evaluations, choices, and actions” (Lefkowitz, 2003, p. 139).

### *The values of organizational psychology and the scientist–practitioner model*

So, with that very brief normative description of professional values as a point of departure, how do the values of organizational psychology compare? That is a tricky question as there appear to be no explicit statements of what our values might be—although a number of values might reasonably be inferred from various indicators describing the nature of our work and expressed opinions (Lefkowitz, 2005).

The entire extent of our explicitly avowed values system seems to be encapsulated by the ubiquitous “scientist–practitioner (S-P) model,” even though there are precious few written explanations of exactly what that entails. As applied to organizational psychology, we can define it simply as a view that promotes the process of understanding and improving the structure and functioning of organizations and the people within them, by means of rigorous scientific methods. But that leaves a fair amount unspecified. It indicates that “understanding” organizations (i.e., our *science*) and “improving” organizations (i.e., *professional practice*) are both important. Or, as expressed recently in TIP: “Good Science–Good Practice” (Madigan & Dickson, 2007). But what do we mean by being “scientific?” And what are the goals and objectives that designate what we mean by “improvement?” Those are what reflect the values that underlie the model. What might they be? And what laudatory values might be omitted?

The S-P model in organizational psychology is regularly the object of a fair amount of concern and/or criticism (e.g., Hays-Thomas, 2006; Rupp & Beal, 2007). Those critiques, however, usually entail complaints such as the model fails to articulate the nature of the relationship between the two components, or it fails to effectively guide graduate training in that professional practice issues are given short shrift (Katzell & Austin, 1992). The issues that concern me are rather different. Borrowing from the technical language of personnel selection, specifically criterion development, I have argued (Lefkowitz, 1990) that our S-P values system is biased by being both *deficient* and *contaminated*: it is deficient in its relative failure to represent the interests of individuals and the common good (“society”)—one of psychology’s “two cultures” (Kimble, 1984). It is contaminated by having been largely consumed by the traditional economic free-enterprise, shareholder-value-above-all-else agenda. And these biases have had, I will attempt to illustrate, a number of adverse consequences.

### *Organizational psychology’s implicit values and suggested modifications*

I have not been able to find any published statements of what are the values of organizational psychology, other than general endorsements of the S-P model—notwithstanding considerable disagreement among ourselves concerning the definition and meaning of that model (Rupp & Beal, 2007). But as psychologists, we are familiar with the process of inferring individual personality attributes, character traits, values, etc., on the basis of a person’s overt behavior and verbal expressions. The same is possible, I would argue, at the institutional level, allowing us to infer much about the values of a profession from its history, current actions and expressed institutional concerns, and from what it chooses to avoid or ignore. What follows are some indicators for consideration. They are not independent; as reflective of an underlying value system they are inevitably interrelated—even overlapping.

#### **Our version of the S-P model replaces psychology’s humanist tradition with economic business goals**

Most organizational psychologists are probably aware of the origins of the S-P model as a model for the graduate training of clinical psychologists (Raimy, 1950). So why is it apparently an acceptable (or at least apt) model for clinical psychology but putatively deficient, as I contend, when applied to

organizational psychology? The answer lies in the value differences that comprise the practitioner portion of the model within the two fields:

It is reasonable to equate clinical practice—a helping profession—with the ethical dimension of beneficence and the values of humanism. . . . Although it would be unfair and misleading to suggest that I/O psychologists are not also motivated by an ideal of helping people (*cf.* Church & Burke, 1992), it is probably inaccurate to similarly equate I/O practice with the values of humanism. In the case of I/O Psychology, the “practitioner” portion of the S-P Model is not driven primarily by the beneficent concerns that are part of the heritage of psychology and part of our professional/ethical obligations. Thus, for I/O Psychology the S-P Model is incomplete. (Lefkowitz, 2003, p. 292).

But it is not merely incomplete; it seems readily apparent that the values represented by the practitioner portion of the S-P model in organizational psychology are dominated by the business values of an idealized free-market capitalism. I believe that the opinion expressed in a renowned text is probably representative: “Humanistic values represent a problem for the field of organizational psychology because these features can conflict with the objectivity required of a science and because they can dilute a strong concern for performance effectiveness and productivity” (Miner, 1992, p. 293). Although the consequences of the free-enterprise system that enshrines productivity and shareholder value above all else are certainly not without considerable societal benefits, we would be remiss not to acknowledge that those consequences frequently conflict with our professional obligations “to improve the condition of individuals, organizations, *and* society” (APA, 2002, *emphasis added*).

At this point, it should be recognized that levels of analysis issues can be very important with respect to the study of values. Agle and Caldwell (1999) articulated five levels as appropriate for the study of business values—individual, organizational, institutional, societal, and global.<sup>2</sup> For example, few would deny that “competition” is a salient hallmark of the capitalist-free market economic system. Yet even Adam Smith recognized that it tends not to be a personal value of those who run business enterprises—they can generally be counted on to engage in anti-competitive or monopolistic practices if allowed the freedom to do so. Smith, in fact, viewed business leaders as one of the two great threats to free markets—along with excessive government regulation.

In the present instance, based on the only relevant data I could find, my characterization of organizational psychology *qua* profession seems to describe accurately the views of its individual practitioners. Among 31 values statements rated by 96 organizational practitioners, the three top-rated values were *increasing effectiveness and efficiency*, *enhancing productivity*, and *promoting quality of products and services*. Rated near the bottom of the list were *humanizing the work place*, *promoting autonomy and freedom*, *promoting democratic systems and policies*, *establishing systems based on equality*, and *emphasizing individual welfare* over the organization’s (Church & Burke, 1992).

I suggest that because the interests of individual employees and the commonweal are sometimes not commensurate with those of the organization and its shareholders we should broaden our areas of concern. My earlier plea that the S-P model in organizational psychology should be replaced by a Scientist–Practitioner–Humanist (S-P-H) model (Lefkowitz, 1990) was, admittedly, somewhat vague—although implications were elaborated later (Lefkowitz, 2003). Others have since observed that “improving the human condition at work is the correct goal for us to pursue given our background as psychologists and the unique training we receive (Gasser, Butler, Waddilove, & Tan, 2004),

<sup>2</sup>The situation becomes more complicated still if one distinguishes between two different (but possibly overlapping) value systems—one that is rational, conscious, and intentional, and one that is more experiential, preconscious, and affective (Epstein, 1989). The former is generally thought of as normative or prescriptive and espoused–volitional views of what ought to be. The latter is more automatic and action oriented—“normal values in use” that generally must be inferred (Argyris & Shon, 1978; Reese & Fremouw, 1984).

and more recently Muchinsky (2006) has offered *organizational health psychology* as the directing force for I/O psychology—“making organizations great places to work.”<sup>3</sup> That should always be the meta-objective; it privileges the position of employees at least equal to that of shareholders. But as noted earlier our concerns, as *professionals*, properly extend beyond the welfare of individual employees to include the manifest effects of organizational policies—concordant with notions like the *multiple stakeholder approach*, *corporate citizenship*, and *corporate social responsibility* of business organizations (Donaldson & Preston, 1995; Lefkowitz, 2007; Post, Frederick, Lawrence, & Weber, 1996). Another way to expand our concerns is to increase the extent of our professional practice with “underserved” constituencies such as non-profit organizations and non-traditional employees—the contingent workforce (Lefkowitz, 2005; Lefkowitz, Finkelman, & Redmond, 2006), and by adopting a leadership and modeling role within organizations concerning good ethical practices (Lefkowitz, 2004; Wiley, 1998).

### **We are overly “scientific”**

The Nobel Laureate in economics, Friedrich Hayek, devoted his Nobel acceptance speech to warning of the errors and dangers of a “scientific attitude” in economics (Hayek, 1989). What he was referring to is an unthinking and inappropriate imitation of the procedures and thought processes developed in the physical sciences, leading to what he referred to as “the pretence of knowledge” that marks much of social science:

...in the social sciences often that is treated as important which happens to be accessible to measurement. . . .

We know, of course. . . , a great many facts which we cannot measure and on which indeed we have only some very imprecise and general information. And because the effects of these facts in any particular instance cannot be confirmed by quantitative evidence, they are simply disregarded by those sworn to admit only what they regard as scientific evidence: they thereupon happily proceed on the fiction that the factors which they can measure are the only ones that are relevant (p. 3).

We view ourselves as being entirely objective and scientific in our professional activities, guided by dispassionate theories and empirical “facts” determined entirely by objective methods—all without the intrusion of personal or social values. We maintain that our field is entirely scientific and “value-free.” But, at the very least, that conflates *instrumental values* with *terminal values*. Even if our methods were entirely objective, one can hardly make the same claim for our organizationally and economically driven goals and objectives. Moreover, the very assumption of a fact/value distinction is arguably spurious in organizational psychology—perhaps in all social science—because many of the “facts” we consider are value-laden (e.g., test bias and fairness; criterion relevance; organizational justice; etc.), and/or reflect organizational policy decisions, personnel actions, etc., that are determined by institutional values and are evaluated by us as “appropriate” or not in accord with that same value system. In a similar vein, Eastman and Bailey (1998) note that maintaining a formalistic distinction between that which we call objective and scientific and hold as factual versus that which we view as subjective and values based and hold with passion is just one historic mode of dealing with the tension between the two poles (i.e., by ignoring their articulation). But, analogous to the way in which modern psychology no longer maintains a clear distinction between cognition and emotion, the relationship between the two poles needs to be explained. “Controversial moral or political positions constitute key

<sup>3</sup>Muchinsky differentiates his proposed focus on *organizational health psychology* from the existing emerging field of *occupational health psychology* by its emphasis on organizations of all sorts, not just work organizations, and by a focus on helping people adapt to rapid economic and social change.



elements of disciplinary knowledge that are denied or suppressed in the formalist and consensualist perspectives. . . . [The past] rhetorical commitment to social scientific inquiry is a thin cover for unacknowledged and undebated ideology” (Eastman & Bailey, 1998, pp. 239, 243).<sup>4</sup>

Indeed, the value-free assertion has become a debatable characterization of even the natural sciences: “Developments in philosophy of science over the past several decades have challenged the assumption of the value neutrality of science. The result has been a growing consensus that science is not and cannot be value free. . . .” (Kurtines, Alvarez, & Azmitia, 1990, p. 283). It is certainly a tenuous assertion in social science, especially *applied* social science, in which betterment of the human condition has always been one of the avowed goals (Rosenberg, 1995). (One cannot define what is “better” without making values choices.) And it is a ludicrous assertion when applied to *professional practice* in organizational psychology, which is aimed primarily at furthering the organization’s values and business objectives. The practitioner aspect of the S-P model is not value free, it incorporates all of the traditional corporatist values. And those values drive even our supposedly objective, scientific research; and they are often incompatible with psychology’s humanist tradition (Kimble, 1984; Stagner, 1982). It is only because the professional values of organizational psychologists are so consonant with the corporate value system within which we function that we can misperceive our work as “value-free.”

It is becoming more widely recognized in social science—if not yet much so in organizational psychology—that values infuse much of what we study and how we study it and apply it and that there is a downside to maintaining the fiction that they do not. “A social science that sought to efface the moral dimension from its descriptions and explanations would simply serve the interests of some other moral conception. It would reflect values foreign to those that animate our conception of ourselves” (Rosenberg, 1995, p. 205). As suggested earlier, that is what I believe has happened in organizational psychology: the corporate value system has filled the vacuum created by the denial of our humanist tradition in the service of trying to deny the legitimacy of any ideology. Focusing on the underlying issue, Ghoshal (2005, p. 87) observed that “social scientists carry an even greater social and moral responsibility than those who work in the physical sciences because, if they hide ideology in the pretense of science, they can cause much more harm.”

I would argue that organizational psychology is so heavily invested in the scientific attitude, denying any relevance to ideological positions or social values, that it has led to some significant blind spots and ironies—such as viewing humanistic values as necessarily antithetical to “objective science” but failing to recognize that “a strong concern for performance effectiveness and productivity” (Miner, 1992, p. 293) is just as value-laden. To illustrate some additional apparent blind spots, let us focus on an area of work by I/O psychologists that is generally viewed as completely objective, truly scientific, and free from values bias or other social influences—the quantitative criterion-related validation of personnel selection tests. Yet, the following illustrative matters are troubling and should be considered.

(a) Based on almost 20 years of published research (138 validation studies), it was observed that studies conducted by those concerned about equal employment opportunity (EEO) legal compliance yielded significantly higher validity findings than did studies conducted by those who simply wished to obtain a high validity (a difference of approximately one-third greater utility) (Russell et al., 1994). And studies conducted by those concerned about EEO issues or with augmenting existing selection systems obtained significantly higher validities than did those concerned with testing a theory (a difference of approximately 50 per cent greater utility). The authors observed that the latter difference is comparable in magnitude to those used to infer that some types of predictors are more valid than others. They conclude that even validity generalization results “can still be influenced by the capabilities and motivational agendas of the original investigators and must be used with caution in

<sup>4</sup>“Consensualism” represents theoretical positions that attempted an equilibrium between the two modes.

guiding theory development” (p. 169). But in 13 years no such cautionary attitude regarding the potential influence of personal and social values or aims of the researcher–practitioner has found its way into I/O psychology’s conventional wisdom regarding test validity findings.

(b) As reported by Stauffer and Buckley (2005, p. 589), several important reviews and meta-analyses have somehow failed to note that there is “clear evidence for bias” in the performance ratings made by black and white supervisors of their subordinates. From a practical standpoint, “if you are a White ratee, then it does not matter whether your supervisor is Black or White. If you a Black ratee, then it is important whether your supervisor is Black or White” (p. 589). Admittedly, the data were not adequate to determine whether the bias stemmed from white supervisors under-valuing the performance of blacks or of black supervisors over-evaluating the same group. But that is not the point. The implications of the findings are quite substantial: they call into question the legitimacy of personnel actions based on supervisory performance appraisals; they challenge the conventional wisdom that such ratings are not biased; and most important, because analyses of predictive test bias necessarily assume the absence of criterion bias, they call into question one of the foundations of personnel selection—the conclusion that selection tests are not biased. The point is not whether rater bias will ultimately be confirmed and legitimately attributed to racial prejudice; it concerns the failure of these data to have been considered appropriately in several prior analyses, as well as the profound silence with which the Stauffer and Buckley conclusion has been met within I/O psychology.

(c) It has been a decade since it was apparently demonstrated that the only means of investigating and detecting predictive racial bias in selection tests that is “approved” and endorsed by our field (SIOP, 2003) is, in fact, “incorrect and biased against minorities” (Terry, 1997, p. 25), and that, in any event, if a test is shown under realistic conditions to not be biased in the predictive sense, it is biased in the measurement sense (Millsap, 1995, 1997). Moreover, since the analytic tools were provided (Millsap & Kwok, 2004), it has been shown that in the *absence* of predictive bias, but with measurement bias present, the accuracy of selection for the lower scoring (usually the minority) group is markedly degraded while accuracy for the higher scoring (usually white majority) group is only marginally affected adversely (Millsap, 2007). The implications of these conclusions are potentially staggering for the field of selection testing: our sanguine acceptance that tests are not unfair to minorities may be completely unfounded—based entirely on the literature of predictive bias while ignoring the adverse effects of a failure to achieve measurement invariance. Once again, for my purposes here the issue is not the resolution of the psychometric issues. It is, as noted by others, that these results have been completely ignored in the practice of personnel selection and in the formulation of professional testing standards (Borsboom, 2006) even though (or is it *because*?) they appear to call into question the foundations of our “scientific knowledge” (and lucrative professional practice) in selection testing.

A moment ago I alluded to ironies as well as blind spots as a result of our overly scientific attitude. Arguably the foremost reality of corporate life in America over the past quarter-century has been the wholesale dismissal of millions of employees from their jobs under euphemistic labels like “restructuring,” “re-engineering,” “right-sizing,” etc. Is it not ironic that during that same period of time some of the most heavily researched areas in organizational psychology have included *organizational citizenship behavior*, *conscientiousness* and *integrity*, and *organizational commitment*? Is it merely coincidence that these topics all have to do with enhancing employee contributions to the furtherance of company objectives [during an era in which companies have essentially eliminated the bases of loyalty and career]? Or is it more parsimonious to explain them as reflections of a dominant value system that drives even our putatively objective “scientific” interests?

I suggest that we acknowledge the scientific myths under which we operate and stop viewing ideological values issues entirely as extrinsic contaminants; they are intrinsic to what we do and who we are. This is not a plea to abandon the epistemic values that constitute the scientific method, but to also recognize the inextricable involvement of other ideological positions and consequent blind spots in

our work. The terms of debate should change from “value-free scientific objectivity versus social values” to “which goals and associated sets of values should we advance, under what circumstances, in what proportions and by means of what necessary compromises?”

### **While invariably ethical, we are often amoral**

Because the only values position we have articulated is our version of the S-P model, it has followed that all we need to be concerned with are theoretical and scientific issues on the one hand, and practical or instrumental questions on the other. But, in addition to scientific questions like “is it valid?” and instrumental questions like “is it cost-effective?”, why are there no avowed and salient *normative* questions guiding our work such as: “is it the right thing to do?” In other words, we should strive for not just “Good Science–Good Practice,” but “Good Science–Good Practice–Good Works.”

The reason for the absence of a normative perspective is, I believe, in part due to scientific excess, again. In order to take a normative or moral position, one must move beyond mere description and putatively scientific “value-free” perspectives. One has to take a stand and assert what interpersonal, organizational, political, or societal conditions ought to exist—and defend that position in moral terms. And that—as a profession—we avoid like the plague. Following are two illustrations.

(a) We have conducted a great deal of research on organizational justice, but most of it concerns procedural or interactional justice, not *distributive* justice (e.g., Cropanzano, 1993). To study and draw conclusions regarding distributive justice, one needs to articulate a *normative* view of what distributions are right, fair, or just to use as evaluative standards. That entails a willingness to state what is *not* right, and what is *unfair* or *unjust* about our organizations. Even more tellingly I would argue, we virtually never really investigate organizational justice of any sort—merely its supposed reflection in attitudinal measures of *perceived* justice. That is, we sidestep entirely the normative questions and arguments—unlike other branches of study like sociology, economics, political science, political economy, and moral and political philosophy, which often encompass debates about normative positions.

(b) For more than 20 years, I/O psychologists, in our role as human resources (HR) professionals, have been actively involved in major organizational downsizings and reductions in force (RIFs), for example, developing performance review procedures to determine in a fair manner who should be let go. And we have persisted largely unquestioningly in this role despite considerable evidence (produced by some of our own colleagues) that many of these wholesale RIFs are neither economically justified nor successful (Cascio, 1993, 1995, 2002; McElroy, Morrow, & Rude, 2001; Pfeffer, 1998; Rousseau, 1995). Moreover, as noted earlier, at the same time as all these RIFs are occurring, what we have been studying is how we can select for and enhance the organizational commitment, good citizenship and conscientiousness of employees. It seems to me to be charitable to limit the characterization of those professional concerns in that context as merely “ironic.”

I think we would be well served if we began to accept responsibility for articulating and justifying what we believe ought to be, that is, what organizations ought to be like and how organizations ought to behave from a moral perspective. Points of departure might include a comprehensive focus on organizational health psychology as noted earlier (Cynkar, 2007), with an explicit analysis of the extent to which our organizations distribute the benefits and burdens of employment in accord with that perspective, as well as their impact on the wider society in terms of social justice. And then we should act accordingly, by striving to influence our employers or clients in those directions.

### **We have a pronounced pro-management bias**

Among the conclusions reached by Katzell and Austin (1992, p. 823) after reviewing nearly 100 years of history is that “I-O psychology is still oriented overwhelmingly to the needs of management.” As I have contended, above, we are so attuned to those needs that it has inappropriately co-opted the values



model by which we define ourselves professionally. To the extent that management and worker interests are not always coterminous, we seem invariably to take the managerial perspective. This goes beyond our historical antipathy to organized labor (Zickar, 2001); even in non-unionized situations we seem to reveal a lack of concern that we once had for the individual employee. Two examples can illustrate this criticism: “wrongful discharge” and “strategic HR administration.”

(a) The massive RIFs that have marked the past 25 years in the U.S. have been facilitated by the widespread common law doctrine of *employment at-will* (EAW), in which both employers and employees are free (within well-known restrictions) to terminate the employment at any time, for any cause or even for no cause.<sup>5</sup> Organizational scholars have pointed out that EAW is incompatible with the sense of mutual trust, loyalty, and respect that ought to characterize the workplace (Werhane, 1999) and with modern “high performance” and employee-centered HR practices that build commitment and organizational effectiveness (Dessler, 1999; Huselid, 1995; Pfeffer & Veiga, 1999). Nevertheless, the restrictions alluded to above mean that some dismissals are inappropriate. The major adverse consequences of such *wrongful discharge* of employees, we are warned in an educative treatise by colleagues, is the payment of large damage awards to the discharged worker and lowered organizational morale as a consequence of the resulting litigation (Dunford & Devine, 1998). Why is not an aggrieved person’s legal recovery of damages viewed by us as a *positive* outcome?; and why is lowered morale among the remaining workers attributed to the pursuant litigation by one of their fellow employees, rather than to management’s wrongful discharge itself?

(b) For many years, the HR function in organizations typically represented employee interests and concerns, and the HR manager’s job included confronting issues of fairness on behalf of employees (Skarlicki & Folger, 2003). Nowadays, the dominant HR model is *strategic human resource management* (SHRM), in which HR—no less than any other facet of the organization is to be driven by the maximization of corporate financial objectives and enhancing the firm’s competitive advantage (Wright, 1998). From this perspective, HR policies are justified to the extent that they impact productivity and financial outcomes (Way & Johnson, 2005) and organizational psychologists have similarly focused on demonstrating the utility in financial terms of their interventions and systems (Cascio, 2000). Moreover, just as corporate philanthropy has come more and more to be viewed and justified as “strategic giving” (Carroll & Buchholtz, 2003), ethical concerns may be strategically co-opted: “Because we increasingly recognize that the effective management and utilization of HR can be an important source. . . of sustained competitive advantage. . . , we need to consider different ways that we can implement integrative HR innovations to impact on the bottom line, and this includes ethical considerations” (Buckley et al., 2001, pp. 11, 12).

Just as we believe that we differ from managers and other organizational consultants by virtue of our scientific outlook and training, that is, one of psychology’s “two cultures”—as psychologists we should also be differentiating ourselves by including among our concerns explicit employee advocacy and betterment—reflecting the other of our two cultures. In an era in which even the People’s Republic of China, over the objections of global companies doing business there, is granting greater rights and legal protections to its workers (Kahn & Barboza, 2007), this seems a modest agenda item.

### **We focus myopically on “means,” to the virtual exclusion of “ends”**

At least since Munsterberg (1913), we have accepted the morally anemic technocratic view that

Economic psychotechnics may serve certain ends of commerce and industry, but whether these ends are the best ones is not a care with which the psychologist has to be burdened. . . . The psychologist

<sup>5</sup>Which is like the aphorism variously attributed to a number of different French philosophers and social critics describing a certain version of “liberty”—that both the rich and the poor are free to sleep under the bridges of Paris.

is...not entangled in the economic [i.e., the social and moral] discussions of the day... He [sic] is confined to the statement: If you [i.e., the employer] wish this end, then you must proceed in this way; but it is left to you to express your preference among the ends (p. 19).

But ethics is not simply a matter of technical competence; organizations have become enormously powerful and pervasive; and practicing organizational psychologists should be more than just “hired hands.” Morality cannot be addressed appropriately without appreciable concern for the overall *consequences* of one’s actions—notwithstanding that we have done technically good work. And because we work in and for large organizations, the actions of which have far-reaching societal consequences, we need to be actively engaged in what Munsterberg referred to as the “economic discussions of the day.” Rosenberg’s (1995, p. 205) admonition is well worth repeating: “A social science that sought to efface the moral dimension from its descriptions and explanations would simply serve the interests of some other moral conception. It would reflect values foreign to those that animate our conception of ourselves.” The crux of the matter, of course, is precisely that: what *is* organizational psychology’s conception of itself? And how accurate is that self-image?

But organizational psychology did, indeed, develop along the lines Munsterberg advocated, and almost 50 years later the nature of our work did not go unnoticed by the social historian Baritz (1960) in *The Servants of Power*:

...throughout their professional history, industrial social scientists, without prodding from anyone, have accepted the norms of America’s managers. If this attitude had not tended to influence their work, it would deserve merely passing mention. But this commitment to management’s goals, as opposed to the goals of other groups and classes in American society, did color their research and recommendations... Reducing the pressure of unionism while increasing the productivity of the labor force and thereby lowering costs have been among their most cherished goals, because these have been the goals which management has set for them (pp. 197, 198).

In all fairness it should be acknowledged that Munsterberg’s views, while they prevailed, did not go unchallenged within the field in his time. The first volume of the *Journal of Applied Psychology* contained a paper by Roback (1917) who noted:

...surely the applied psychologist must have a broader outlook on life. He [sic] ought to be able to distinguish between what is *desired* and what is *desirable*, between the professional and the moral issues...

...the engineer is not beset by the question as to whether it is moral for him to undertake the task [of building a bridge]... his task is to determine merely whether a given project is *practicable*. It is different with the applied psychologist who has also to consider the *ethical implications of this task*...

No connivance on the part of a consulting psychologist can be justified on the ground that applied psychology is an *instrumental science* and is, therefore, not concerned with ends. If we choose to accept this professional view, we shall be involved in no end of difficulties. As no purpose is ultimate, or absolute, there will be a tendency to rule out all ends and to ignore every consideration but what is expedient (pp. 234, 241, emphases in the original).

Ironically, much of the business community and business scholars are way ahead of us, as reflected, for example, in the *multiple stakeholder approach*, the *corporate social responsibility* perspective on

organizational decision-making (Lefkowitz, 2007), and the recognized importance of *human capital* (Cascio, 2007).

We should take more seriously the APA ethics code admonition that the goal of psychology is “to improve the condition of individuals, organizations, and society” (APA, 2002, p. 1062). It says “and,” not “or”; that is, it is not like a price-fixed dinner: we are not obliged to choose just one main course. Just because many of us make a living in, or from, organizations, does not mean that we cannot advocate for consideration of a broader societal perspective.

## Summary and Conclusions: Agenda for an Expanded Values Model

I should like to emphasize clearly that the foregoing criticisms have been institutional, not individual. The levels of analysis issue represents a potentially important distinction when thinking about values. For example, as pointed out earlier, *competition* is a near-hallowed value of free market ideology but at the individual level most senior executives—irrespective of how much they might nominally endorse the value—spend a great deal of time and energy scheming about how to eliminate competition. Thus, my criticisms, for example, that organizational psychology is not guided very much by beneficent or humanistic concerns—is an institutional level criticism, not an indictment of individual character deficiency among organizational psychologists. In fact, there exists ample evidence of the generosity of spirit and philanthropic activities of some among us (e.g., Boutelle, 2007; Koppes, 2007; Meyers, 2007).

But among the issues addressed here is not whether, or the extent to which, organizational psychologists are good-hearted individuals. It is whether their beneficence is at all reflective of or conditioned by their education and training, socialization, and experiences as organizational psychologists, that is, by the intrinsic ideology and culture of organizational psychology. The distinction is analogous to not evaluating the social responsibility and ethical performance of a company merely by its external philanthropic activities such as supporting the local symphony orchestra, but by its intrinsic customs, that is, appraising the integrity of its business practices, fairness of its personnel policies, honesty of its marketing and sales procedures and its environmental policies regarding air, ground, and water pollution. More of us should acknowledge that most large hierarchical organizations are psychologically unhealthy for most people who inhabit them (Leavitt, 2007). That does not mean we should not try to humanize them (because we believe that is a social good and because it actually contributes to their productivity). Nevertheless, we can simultaneously assert that “it is not our moral duty simply to serve their interests” (Leavitt, 2007, p. 262), especially if those interests conflict with what ought to be our broader concerns.

Recapitulating briefly: to prosper, the field of organizational psychology should attempt to modify its self-image by expanding its espoused values to encompass a scientist-practitioner-humanist model, within a broader societal perspective. That would entail some proactive changes.

We should accept the wider responsibilities that accompany the privileges and status of a profession by recapturing the humanist tradition that is part of the cultural heritage of psychology. As the president of the American Psychological Association advocated recently,

As our science continues to improve and gains public recognition for value added to decision making, we will find ourselves increasingly drawn into situations where a multitude of social and political interests apply across hierarchies of individuals to whom we owe various degrees of

professional duties. . . . By focusing on the welfare and best interests of the most vulnerable party in the chain of individuals to whom one owes a legitimate professional duty, psychologists optimize the likelihood of a good outcome. At times, the most vulnerable party may be the public at large (Koocher, 2007, p. 381).

Doing so would not, as some fear, introduce contaminating social ideology into an otherwise pristine scientific enterprise. In fact, we need to acknowledge that our scientific research and professional practice are not “value-free,” and never have been; they reflect in a variety of ways the traditional corporatist value system. Admitting our scientific errors will reveal that the supposed simple debate between “objective science versus social values” is a sham. It is a much more complicated set of questions regarding: which sets of objectives and values? Under what circumstances? And to what degree? Where and how do their consequences apparently conflict, and can they be reconciled? We can, of course, choose to privilege the values of productivity and profits over all others, but let us not continue insisting naively or disingenuously that we are being scientific by doing so.

To advance a humanist agenda necessarily entails also accepting responsibility for articulating a normative position of how organizations *ought* to behave from a moral perspective. As often as we express scientific and instrumental concerns like “is it valid?” and “is it cost effective?” we should be asking “is it the right thing to do?” This will also serve to differentiate us from our business competition and from management not just by our methodological expertise but, in the interests of fairness and social justice, by our advocacy of employee rights as well. Morality also requires consideration of the broader societal consequences of organizational actions and our contributions to them, not merely whether we have fulfilled our assigned role(s) in a technically competent manner. This is commensurate, for example, with Carr’s (2007, p. 48) recent call to “expand our own definition of I/O psychology” to help organizations contribute to the reduction of world poverty.

To anticipate the obvious criticism of this proposed agenda, would not it place us in apparent opposition to the predominant aims of our employers and clients? At least some of the time, and for some employers and clients, probably yes. But (a) balancing multiple worthy objectives and needs of multiple constituencies is precisely what contemporary executives schooled in strategic stakeholder management do all the time. And HR professionals are frequently admired by organization decision-makers for providing such ethical guidance (Wiley, 1998); (b) are the objectives really in opposition? Do not we believe that a humanist agenda, promoting fairness, respect, and organizational justice, contributes to organizational business objectives? (c) Evidence has accumulated that manifesting broader societal concerns actually promotes corporate financial performance (Orlitzky, Schmidt, & Rynes, 2003); and lastly (d) in an era marked by extensive corporate participation in the *UN Global Compact* and *Millennium Development Goals* (United Nations, 2007; World Business Council for Sustainable Development, 2005) and the growing numbers of organizations intentionally attempting to effect positive societal changes (Bies, Bartunek, Fort, & Zald, 2007) some optimism seems warranted.

## Author biography

**Joel Lefkowitz** received the Ph.D. in Psychology (Industrial-Organizational specialization) from Case Western Reserve University in 1965. He has been teaching since then at the Bernard M. Baruch College of the City University of New York, where he is currently Professor of Psychology. He was instrumental in the creation of CUNY’s I-O Psychology doctoral program in 1982, which he has

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